

The Food-First Guide

A practical framework for feeling and performing at your best. By Kristen Wight.

Welcome

Welcome. I am so glad you are here.

Food is more than nutrition. It is the raw material your body uses to build, repair, and power every cell. What you eat becomes the version of you that shows up for the life you are building.

This guide is the framework that brought my body back at 40. It is simple and accessible, not another diet plan.

Inside, you will find the foundational practices that quietly transformed my energy, my focus, and my sense of well-being. Two power foods, one bonus element, and a handful of principles that hold it all together.

This is not about perfection. Use it as a reference and come back to it whenever you need a reset.

Kristen

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Why Food Matters (More Than Anyone Told Us)

I have been interested in wellness my entire life. I attended a top nutrition school. I lived at a holistic retreat center for seven months. At 40, my body still started to break down.

It began with small things. Some gut inflammation in the form of silent reflux, a constant lump-in-the-throat sensation, and a lot of throat clearing. Nightly back pain. When I looked at pictures of myself from that period, I looked bloated. I had gone up a clothing size despite walking five miles most days.

By fall of 2022, I was in trouble. Multiple head colds. Chronic asthma. The asthma I had mostly grown out of as a kid was back. My doctor even put me on inhaled steroids.

My mental health was suffering too. I was constantly worrying. When things were at their worst, I could barely function. I was having panic attacks. I felt a heavy, low-grade depression that would not lift. For months I felt terrible: brain fog, anxiety, fatigue, dry coughing.

My doctor was treating symptoms. No one was treating the cause.

It turns out all of the symptoms I had been experiencing were actually downstream of my gut. When the gut microbiome gets out of balance, a long list of seemingly unrelated health issues can show up. Once I started eating differently, things gradually improved. Within a few months, my body

started to come back. The panic attacks quieted. The asthma eased. The brain fog lifted. I felt like myself again.

A note on the gut-brain connection

The gut and the brain talk to each other constantly through the vagus nerve. Roughly ninety percent of the body's serotonin is produced in the gut. When my gut microbiome was out of balance, my mood was too. Better nutrition was one of the pieces that helped me feel like myself again. It was not the only piece. But it was a foundational piece I could control.

A note if you are struggling

If you are experiencing depression, anxiety, or thoughts of self-harm, please reach out to a qualified mental health professional. Food and lifestyle are supportive tools, not replacements for care. In the United States, the 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline is available around the clock by calling or texting 988.

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The Core Principles

Here are the key practices for getting more quality food into your body:

- Be mindful of where your food comes from. Buy local as much as possible.
- Eat certified organic when you can.
- Chew and savor each bite.
- Drink water throughout the day, as needed.
- Listen to your body. Stick to foods that make you feel good.
- Try the whole-foods version of what you are craving. If you want sweets, eat a piece of fruit.
- Cook at home more. Eat out less.
- Try new things.

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A Note on Whole Foods

Whole foods include vegetables, beans, legumes, fruits, grains, meat, poultry, fish, and dairy. These are the foundation.

Here is the thing about diet rules: everyone is bio-individual. What works for one person can leave another person depleted. There is no perfect ratio. There is your ratio, and it takes some attention to find.

What I have found, for myself and for the people I work with, is that the body thrives on plenty of vegetables and plenty of high-quality protein. I lean into both.

I limit grains, especially wheat. Wheat is heavily processed and heavily sprayed with pesticides, and most people feel better when they reduce it. When you do eat grains, choose minimally processed forms (whole oats, brown rice, quinoa, sourdough) and go organic whenever possible.

Whole foods can taste bland if you are used to a lot of processed foods. Season generously with herbs, spices, and healthy condiments.

Listen to your body. Pay attention to how foods make you feel. Your body will tell you.

If you eat animal protein, honor the animal. Buy from local farmers who treat their animals humanely. Gratitude is part of the practice.

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Top Power Food #1: Greens

Green vegetables are arguably the most powerful, life-affirming, nutrient-dense foods you can eat. They are also the most commonly missing food in modern diets.

What greens do for you

- Oxygenate and strengthen the blood
- Improve circulation
- Support the body's natural detoxification
- Fight inflammation
- Neutralize acidic conditions in the body
- Calm the nervous system

Greens are at their most nutrient-dense when eaten raw.

Easy ways to add raw greens

- Make a simple seasonal salad. Try arugula, endive, chicory, lettuce, mesclun, or wild greens.
- Juice them. Go slow at first, since green juice is detoxifying.
- Shred harder greens like Brussels sprouts and add them to salads.

For cooked greens

Steam them just enough to keep their vibrant color. If they lose the color, they are overcooked.

Greens to try

- Kale
- Bok Choy
- Napa Cabbage
- Collards

- Watercress
- Mustard Greens
- Broccoli Rabe
- Dandelion

If you can only do ONE thing for your health, add greens to your diet. Crowd out less healthy foods by making space for greens first.

Lighten your energy. Eat more greens.

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Top Power Food #2: High-Quality Protein

Protein is one of the most powerful foods to lean into intentionally. Most modern diets contain plenty of total protein on paper. What varies is the quality, the source, and the timing. The cleaner the source, the more your body can actually use it for building, steadying, and repairing you.

The standard recommended daily allowance is a floor, not a ceiling. Your body's real needs for muscle, mood, hormones, and tissue repair often run higher than that floor, especially as we move through midlife.

High-quality protein is one of the most life-affirming, grounding foods you can put into your body. Where greens lift your energy, protein steadies you. Quality is everything here.

Where to look for quality protein

- Pasture-raised eggs (an everyday powerhouse)
- Wild-caught fish, especially smaller fish lower on the food chain
- Pasture-raised poultry from local farms
- Grass-fed, grass-finished beef from farms you trust
- Full-fat dairy from grass-fed cows (yogurt, kefir, cheese)
- For plant-based eaters: lentils, beans, hemp seeds, pumpkin seeds, tempeh

I personally lean into animal protein because my body thrives on it. If you are vegetarian or vegan, the plant sources above will serve you well. The key is consistency. Aim for a high-quality protein source at every meal.

For animal protein, sourcing matters. Honor the animal. Buy from local farmers who raise animals humanely. The energy of how the animal lived comes through in the food.

A common sign that your body wants more or better protein: feeling shaky, snacky, or unable to focus a couple of hours after eating. Your nervous system is asking for it.

Add high-quality protein to your daily life with intention. Your body will thank you within days.

A quick note on fats: Quality protein sources like pasture-raised eggs, wild-caught fish, grass-fed meat, and full-fat dairy naturally include healthy fats. You don't need to fear these fats. They are essential for brain function, hormone production, and feeling full between meals. When you choose high-quality protein, you are already getting the fats your body needs.

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The Bonus Element: Hydration

Water is more than a nutrient. Your body is roughly sixty percent water. Every cellular process depends on it. When you starve your cells of water, your body sends signals: fatigue, hunger, headaches, sugar cravings, brain fog.

Water flushes toxins. Water fights inflammation. Water carries every nutrient to every cell.

A note on electrolytes

Plain water alone is not always enough. Your cells need minerals (sodium, potassium, magnesium, chloride) to actually use the water you drink. If you exercise, sweat, drink coffee, or live a high-stress life, you are likely depleting electrolytes faster than you are replacing them.

Simple ways to add electrolytes back:

- A pinch of high-quality sea salt or Himalayan salt in your morning water
- A squeeze of fresh citrus
- Trace mineral drops added to your water bottle
- Coconut water (in moderation)
- Electrolyte powders or tablets (look for clean brands without added sugar or artificial colors)

Water and intention

Photographer Dr. Masaru Emoto captured images of water crystals that appeared to respond to words and thoughts. His work is contested scientifically, but the invitation stays with me. If thoughts shape your nervous system, and your body is mostly water, then how you speak to yourself might matter more than we know.

The practical takeaway is the same regardless of how you read his images: drink with awareness. Pause before you take a sip. Set an intention. Then drink. That small moment of presence changes both the drinking and the drinker.

Daily water practice

- Use a beautiful, reusable water bottle you enjoy holding.
- Drink most of your water earlier in the day. You do not want to disrupt your sleep.
- Do not over-drink. Too much water flushes out vitamins and minerals your body needs.
- Pair each glass with a small mindful pause.

A Note on Balance

This is just a guide. You do not have to follow it perfectly. You do not have to obsess over the quality of every bite.

I want to share something personal. I struggled with my weight and my body image for most of my life. I was orthorexic in nutrition school. The root of my obsession with healthy eating was actually poor body image. I know I am not alone in this.

If you are someone who has dieted hard and worried about your weight, use this guide gently. Hold the intention of balancing out years of food deprivation. Aim for a natural state of eating, not a restrictive one. Allow yourself treats. Go with the flow. Your weight may fluctuate within a 10-pound range, and that is normal.

You are beautiful at any size. Beauty is energy. When you emanate confidence and joy, that is what is irresistible. The right fuel raises your baseline. When you are well-nourished, you radiate. It really is that simple.

Do the best you can. Stay vibrant and balanced.

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Quick Reference

When in doubt:

- Add greens
- Eat high-quality protein at every meal
- Hydrate with mineralized water
- Eat whole foods
- Cook at home
- Pay attention to how foods make you feel
- Trust your body
- Honor your sources
- Allow yourself joy

What Shaped This

Every framework has influences. Mine include:

- The Institute for Integrative Nutrition (IIN): gave me formal training in integrative nutrition and holistic wellness.
- Dr. Mark Hyman: a functional medicine mentor from IIN who shaped my understanding of food as medicine, root-cause healing, and gut health.
- The Celestine Prophecy by James Redfield: planted the idea in my twenties that food is energy.
- Deepak Chopra: deepened my understanding of the mind-body connection as one integrated system.
- Dr. Masaru Emoto: invited me to consider how thoughts might imprint on physical matter.

The framework you just read is the intersection of these influences with over fifteen years of my own experimentation, teaching, and lived experience.

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Thank You

Thank you for reading. If any part of this shifted something in you, if you tried one practice this week, if you felt a little more like yourself, that is enough.

Come back to this guide whenever you need a reset. Reach out at kewight1@asu.edu with questions or feedback.

Kristen